

So it was that on November 25, 2021, the PM laid the foundation stone for the project in a public ceremony that attracted thousands of excited villagers, especially women, who turned up in hordes, singing popular folk songs. "NIA will help drive economic growth and job creation in the region. The airport partners will directly employ 4,000-5,000 men and women from the region. The project will also help create thousands of job opportunities indirectly," says Schnellmann. Already, the project partners are examining ways of offering work to locals during the construction phase.

CHAPTER 3 AEROTROPOLIS

A new concept in urban planning, an aerotropolis is a city whose infrastructure, land use and economy are centred around an airport, which provides fast connectivity to different parts of the world. In the age of Industry 4.0, an aerotropolis will prove to be a disruptor. "The biggest disruption could be in the use of technology in design, operation and data management, which could influence consumer behaviour and customer experience for passengers, airlines or service providers, and redefine cost and efficiency of operations for aero or non-aero businesses," says an aviation expert requesting anonymity.

Then, even as Singapore became the preferred gateway for trade in Asia over the past 15 years, India is poised to become a part of the next growth gateway. "Airports and seaports are critical infrastructure to provide a fulcrum for gateways and we have seen the success of the symbiotic aggregation between such critical infra in the Middle-East and the rest of Asia," observes Tomar. "Across India, there has never been such a large-scale greenfield airport project. The growth in domestic trade has been propelled [so far] by leveraging the existing airport infrastructure. NIA is truly an opportunity for Indian aviation and trade to take a step towards becoming a global gateway."

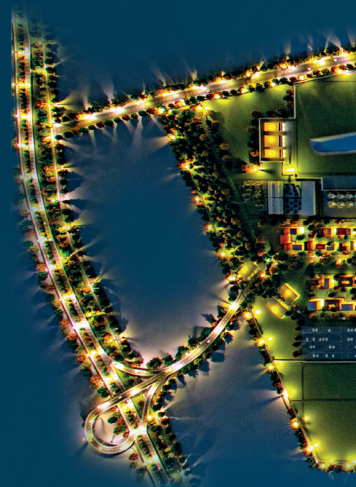
Compared to other airports in India, NIA has two advantages, according to Tomar. First, its location in one of the highest consumption states and abundance of skilled manpower with connectivity to key transport gateways within India provides a significant advantage to manufacturers, logistics players and multi-modal aggregators. Second, the greenfield development has been conceptualised in terms of 'design to sustain' rather than 'design to optimise'. "In the case of design to sustain, the principles

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MILLION
EXPECTED ANNUAL
PASSENGER HANDLING
CAPACITY OF NIA BY
2060, THE LAST YEAR
OF THE CONCESSION
PERIOD FOR
FLUGHAFEN ZÜRICH



YAMUNA INTERNATIONAL AIRPORT PVT. LTD (YIAPL)

A special purpose vehicle, the project's concessionaire is a 100 per cent subsidiary of Flughafen Zürich

GRAPHICS BY RAHUL SHARMA

of design are focussed on building sustainability under high-growth environments and offer significant room to grow the business over several years," says Tomar.

In NIA's case, the first phase of 1,334 hectares will be followed by the second phase on a similar-sized land parcel, for which land acquisition has already started. For subsequent phases, another 5,000 hectares are proposed to be acquired. By the end of the concession period for Flughafen Zürich in 2060, the number of runways at NIA is planned to expand to six, and passenger traffic in excess of 70 million annually. "Considering the size of the Indian consumer market, the project has the potential to transform into the largest aviation logistics hub in Asia-Pacific," says Neha Singh, Associate Partner at law firm Link Legal. Current logistics hubs like Hong Kong, Doha and Japan are definite competitors. But NIA is an important development in the Indian aviation